Removing unwanted browser extensions

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Summary

This article helps users and service-desk agents identify and remove unwanted or malicious browser extensions that cause Chrome or Edge to fail to start, run slowly, show certificate errors, or generate pop-ups and redirects. It includes a self-help procedure for users to disable or delete extensions and a detailed agent workflow for verification, cleaning, and escalation.

Symptoms

- Chrome fails to launch or crashes immediately after clicking the icon
- Microsoft Edge opens but page loading is extremely slow with high CPU usage
- Certificate error warnings appear when trying to reach internal Acme sites (e.g., NET::ERR_CERT_DATE_INVALID)
- Frequent pop-up windows and automatic redirects to unfamiliar advertising or shopping sites
- Unwanted toolbars, search bars, or new-tab pages appear without user action

Common causes

- Installation of malicious or unwanted browser extensions (adware, spyware, or potentially unwanted programs)
- Corrupted browser profile or settings caused by the extension
- Incorrect system date/time leading to certificate validation failures
- Out-of-date browser version that lacks recent security patches

Overview

Unwanted browser extensions are small add-ons that modify browser behavior, often installed inadvertently through freeware bundles or misleading advertisements. They can inject ads, redirect searches, harvest browsing data, and interfere with normal browser operation, leading to the symptoms described above.

Self-Help Procedure: Remove Unwanted Extensions

Follow these steps to check for and remove suspicious extensions in Chrome or Edge. Performing these actions often restores normal browser performance and eliminates pop-ups or certificate warnings.

1. Open the browser and click the three-dot menu in the upper-right corner.
2. Select "Extensions" then "Manage extensions" (Chrome) or "Extensions" (Edge).
3. Review the list of installed extensions. Look for any you do not recognize or that were installed recently.
4. For each suspicious extension, toggle the switch off to disable it, then click "Remove" to uninstall.
5. After removing extensions, close and reopen the browser to test if the issue persists.
6. If the problem remains, clear the browser cache: Settings -> Privacy and security -> Clear browsing data -> choose "Cached images and files" and "Cookies and other site data", then click "Clear data".
7. Restart the browser again and verify normal operation.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports browser issues potentially caused by unwanted extensions, follow this workflow to diagnose, remediate, and document the resolution. This procedure ensures consistent handling and proper escalation when needed.

1. Greet the user and confirm the symptoms (e.g., Chrome not opening, Edge slow, pop-ups). Ask whether they have recently installed any new software or browser add-ons.
2. Remotely connect to the user's device via the approved support tool (Teams screen share or Remote Help).
3. Check the system date and time; if incorrect, correct it and note that certificate errors may resolve.
4. Open the affected browser and navigate to the extensions page (chrome://extensions or edge://extensions).
5. Identify any unknown or suspicious extensions. Disable each one, then test browser performance after each disable.
6. If performance improves, proceed to remove the offending extension(s). Document the name(s) removed.
7. After removal, clear the browser cache and cookies as described in the self-help steps.

8. Run a quick antivirus scan using Microsoft Defender for Endpoint (via the Company Portal) to ensure no related malware remains.
9. Verify that the user can now launch the browser, access internal Acme sites without certificate warnings, and that pop-ups have ceased.
10. Close the session, ask the user to confirm the issue is resolved, and document the steps taken in the ticket.

Verification

After completing the remediation steps, perform these checks to ensure the browser is functioning correctly and that no unwanted extensions remain.

1. Launch Chrome and Edge and confirm they open without delay or crash.
2. Visit a known internal site (e.g., https://intranet.acme.example) and verify no certificate error appears.
3. Open a new tab and check that the default search engine and homepage are as expected.
4. Navigate to a few external sites and observe that no pop-ups or automatic redirects occur.
5. Re-open the extensions page and confirm that only legitimate, approved extensions remain enabled.

When to escalate

If the browser continues to exhibit problems after removing extensions, clearing cache, and verifying system time, escalate to the Desktop Support group. Include in the escalation: the browser version, list of extensions examined, any error messages captured, screenshots of the issue, and confirmation that Defender scan completed cleanly.

Keywords: browser extension, unwanted extension, malicious add-on, Chrome slow, Edge pop-up, certificate error, browser reset, remove extension, adware, spyware